Photo Editing





Why you should edit your photos ?

Because You Want to Take Your Photos to The Next Level!

Arches National Park - Utah.

- Your images always need to be processed, it's simply a question as to whether you - human - want to control this process, or let a machine do it.

- You are given a second chance: You will be able to correct some imperfections and minor mistakes.

- You will be able to create a specific mood and enhance or transform a captured atmosphere.

- It will empower you to develop your very own style.

- It will add business and professional value to your photos.

Preliminary Steps

- On a DSLR, make sure you are 'shooting' RAW. In such case, selecting both JPG and RAW is rarely useful.
If using an iPhone 12 Pro or newer in the Pro series, use ProRAW to shoot to get DNG image files.
If using a Non-Pro iPhone use the High Efficiency format. (HEIC)

- Always prefer the largest image pixel dimensions that your camera can handle.

- Regularly empty your camera or iPhone of stored pictures. For DSLR, clearing entirely is best.
For iPhones, keep only the very best ones you want to share via mail, messages, etc.

- Don't buy just yet an expensive subscription to some famous 'pro' software. You will not need it yet.

- Don't rush to try out complex image processing software. Most are very good, but also sometimes very hard to set up and their learning curve is always very steep.

- Computer monitor: Make sure that your computer monitor is properly setup and displays accurate and faithful colors.
Ideally, you should 'color calibrate' your monitor regularly.

- Backup: Setup a backup solution for the pictures on your computer.

Culling

Culling is the very important process of reviewing a large batch of raw photos and selecting only the strongest images while discarding duplicates, blurry shots, and technical mistakes **before** you start editing.

Why Culling is SO Important?

- It saves time: Editing and tagging every single photo from a photoshoot wastes hours.
Culling cuts down the number of files so you only spend time on the best shots.

- It improves quality: Removing duplicate angles and minor blunders ensures that every image you present meets a high quality standard.

- It prevents fatigue: Looking at hundreds of near-identical pictures might wears out your creative energy.
Culling early keeps your mind fresh for actual editing choices.

- It saves storage space: High-resolution digital files take up massive amounts of hard drive and cloud capacity.
Deleting unused raw files frees up valuable storage.

- It is often more satisfying: We often prefer a tight, curated gallery of amazing moments over a bloated collection filled with repetitive frames.

Tagging

Tagging your photos with keywords, locations, and names is important because it turns a massive, unorganized digital pile into a searchable library.

You will:

- Find images quickly: Typing a word like "dog" or a specific place name lets you locate one photo out of thousands in seconds.

- Save time: You definitely want to avoid scrolling endlessly through years of random pictures to find a single memory.

Benefits:

- Tags let you sort images by people, places, events, or objects.

- Years later, a location or name tag reminds you exactly where a picture was taken or who was in it.

Tagging is optional with Photo Rebel... But is strongly recommended.

Star Ratings

Rating photos with star systems or labels is very important in photo editing because it turns a potentially overwhelming mass of raw images into an organized, efficient workflow.

The Star System is conceptually very simple:

- Zero Star: this photo has never been reviewed yet.

- One Star: Poor image, keep for now, but consider delete.
- Two Stars: Not so good.
- Three Stars: Not bad at all.
- Four Stars: A keeper.
- Five Stars: Gallery worthy photo, your best!

Here are a few reasons why ratings matter:

- Speeds Up Culling: Sorting through hundreds or thousands of shots becomes fast when you browse your library with filters.

- Reduces Decision Fatigue: Separating keepers from discards in multiple quick passes stops you from over-analyzing every single file.

- Creates Editing Priorities: You can filter your software library to show only high-priority photos, ensuring you edit your best work first.

- Simplifies Portfolio Building: Consistent ratings create a permanent, searchable record of your top-tier images for sharing, printing, or publishing.

- Again, find images quickly: Filter using a star level your image library search results.

Ideally, all images in your library should be at least rated 'Two Stars'.

Culling common mistakes

- Editing before culling: Fix the exposure, move on, hit a better version of the same shot ten images later. The time spent on the first frame is wasted. Cull the entire set before beginning editing.

- Keeping images out of emotional attachment: The first time you photograph something — a new venue, a sport you're unfamiliar with, a type of subject — you'll want to keep images because of what they represent to you. Assess the image, not the experience of taking it.

- Delivering too many similar images: Keeping twenty nearly identical frames of the same moment doesn't show talent — it shows you didn't edit with any rigor. Select the best ones.

- Over-trusting Artificial (so called) Intelligence on emotionally complex material.

Before Editing, Remember...

- Make sure your computer monitor is properly setup.
- You should edit your best pictures, and only the best.
- Keep them looking natural.
- Avoid ‘Plastification’: Do not over-smooth, especially for portraits.
- Avoid ‘Cartoonification’: Drive saturation and vibrance ‘responsibly'.
- Mort a la Vignette: Enough is Enough!
- Be nice with the sliders: they do not like to be pushed to the extreme!
- Chances to recover what initially looked like a 'bad' picture are very low.
- Make sure that your edits are actually improving on the original.

Editing - Step One - Geometry

It is very important to proceed in the correct order when editing.
Here is what most 'Pro' photographers consistently do recommend.

Orientation

Some cameras and PC software sometimes do not work together well.
Occasionally, some photos will open up upside down or incorrectly rotated.
This is the very first thing to fix, and that's only pushing a single button.

Mirroring

In the 'western' world we have been taught to read from left to right. Consequently, many people, not everybody though, have a negative 'feeling' or 'discomfort' when a photo shows movement heading from right to left. Mirroring the image often helps, but not always.
Similarly, movement shown moving up is often unconsciously preferred compared to going down.

Something to use wisely though.

Straightening

Straightening a photo corrects a tilted frame so that natural horizons and architectural lines appear level.

Why Straightening Matters ?

- Fixes visual balance: Human eyes naturally expect level lines.

A crooked horizon or leaning building creates subconscious tension or discomfort for the viewer.





Seattle Downtown, Washington - In the above example, the right side of the tall building has been straighten, improving the composition.

- Increases Focus: When lines are straight, the viewer focuses on your main subject instead of wondering why the image feels "off".

- Adds professionalism: Leveling turns a casual snapshot into a polished, deliberate piece of work.

- Improves flow: Straight vertical and horizontal guides help lead the eye smoothly across the composition.

Composition / Framing / Cropping

This is where Editing gives you again a second chance to improve your photos.

It is difficult to patiently frame fugitive instants or take advantage of unique opportunities to snap a memorable image: Recomposing in such cases helps a huge lot!

- Cropping will remove 'distractions' at the edges of the image.

- Cropping will improve your composition: Find the lines that drive the picture and balance them.





Oregon Coast near Cannon Beach — In the above example the horizon line has been made horizontal, the crop has removed some minor distractions on the left side and helps discovering the lighthouse in the background. A large part of the uniform sky has also been removed, while keeping the visually interesting white and dark clouds.

- You will be able to re-center or off-center the protagonists present in the image.

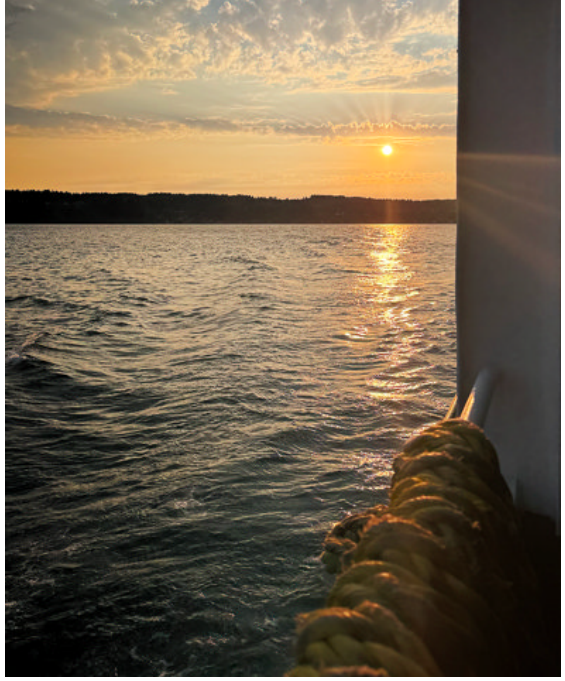
You would follow the classic "Rule of Thirds" or try more elaborate compositions, such as the 'Golden Spiral'.

This step is essential and should not be skipped.

Touch Up

Before going ahead onto the next step, always check for lens flares or other minor defects in your photo.





Ferry Ride on the Puget Sound — In the above example Photo Rebel has been able to remove the “yellow dot” (a lens flare) on the center left of the image. After a few more edits the patch is almost invisible.

Editing - Step Two - Exposure

Once we are done with this 'Geometry' work, comes the 'image processing' sequence of steps.
If your software has this functionality available, you may wish proceed with these adjustments displaying black and white images.

Low Light De-Noising

First thing you should do is to zoom into the image and find out if your image has noise or ‘grain’, typically red and green dots more or less equally spaced in the darker areas of the image.
Photos shots in low light settings are a common example. If so, apply the de-noising filter to eliminate or reduce this 'digital noise'.

However, use noise reduction carefully, too much makes photos waxy and portrait skins look made from plastic.

Global Exposure

- **Shift**: Add some 'brightness' to all pixels of the image. Handle with care as this can destroy the highlights of the

image. Use it only when the histograms are all showing a completely flat line on the right sides. After shifting, you will notice that the histograms actually are shifting left or right, hence the name.

- **Gain**: Multiply 'brightness' to all pixels of the image. Again, use gently, and only if needed.

- **Gamma**: Adjust exposure following a 'gamma' power curve, and more effective in the shadows and mid-tone areas.

Make sure to not overshoot this step, as it could compromise the effectiveness of the next steps.

Highlights and Shadows

On this step, you can somewhat 'tame' some highlights that could be really too bright. Similarly, the shadows can be brightened a bit to reveal details that would be invisible in the dark.

Normally you decide to either boost highlights or shadows, and very rarely both.

Careful, overcooking this step yields images with poor contrast and feeling 'boring'.

Selective Exposure

The most overused effect is the elliptical dark vignette that you should definitely avoid.

However, darkening or brightening one side of the image can create interesting effects and bring some 'life' to what could be a monotonous background.

Using the 'Selective Exposure' tool to recover or rescue a poorly exposed image does not work so well.

'Spotlight' Exposure

The spotlight effect consists in increasing brightness on a specific area of the image, preferably more or less circular.
It is very easy to setup and often yields good results when off-centered, and supporting your geometry choices.





Hiking around Hilo, Hawai'i - In the example above, a quite strong additional exposure has been added on the ferns on the right foreground. The left side of the image has also been slightly highlighted, using the 'Selective Exposure' tool mentioned above, creating 'steps' of luminosity, breaking the monotony of the darker background. Finally, framing and signing the image add a little 'professional' touch to the image. (Detailed later in the Export step)

Editing - Step Three - Colors

Obviously now is the time to turn color back on your display.

White Balance

This step must be completed **before** any other color adjustments.

Bad white balance is why edits look yellow, green, bizarre or lifeless.

Figure out in the image an area that should be white, or gray neutral. Zoom in as necessary to find that spot.
Adjust your white balance settings so that the chosen spot becomes white or gray neutral.





This is one of the 'One-Click' methods available in Photo Rebel.

Adjusting color temperature and the "Gray World" algorithm are also very effective at providing well balanced and natural colors.

Which one to choose ? Try them all until you find a setting that works well…

Contrast

- Global Contrast

Most cameras do not handle contrast as well as the human eye. Therefore, increasing contrast slightly for additional depth is almost always a good move. (Note: Slightly!) Combining this step with a very gentle touch of blur and brightness also helps.
This is a typical case where pushing the sliders too hard can be detrimental.

- Contrast Equalization

This contrast pass (also known as CLAHE) is very effective because changes are applied only where needed and furthermore contrast adjustment is adjusted to local areas of the image instead of globally. Photo Rebel will **soon** support CLAHE.

Color Grading with Lookup Tables

Color Grading Tables also widely known as LUT's, are a perfect tool to apply the same color effect to any image.

Initially developed for video, their use has gained traction in digital photography.

You can download hundreds of LUTs from the Internet and build up a strong library of color effects. Those color effects are immensely varied, cinematic or futuristic effects, moods, specialized for medical applications, etc.

Death Valley, California. - In the example above using a color lookup table completely change the ‘story’. However colors are ‘badly’ oversaturated.

If you are editing a set of pictures for a given event, let's say a wedding, applying the very same "Romantic Pastels" LUT to all your morning shots will save you a huge amount of time of pushing sliders and will bring style consistency to your work. Photo Rebel supports CUBE and 3DL LUT files. It ships with a few sample LUT's and can handle all the ones you may have downloaded from the web or created your self. The Photo Rebel 'LUT Explorer' helps you to easily pick one in your library.

On the downside, LUT are often destructive, sometimes even creating additional digital noise.

Manual Color Grading

Warning ! Over-saturation screams “Beginner”. Use wisely… Always try first to use vibrance instead of saturation.

For portraits:

You should often prefer vibrance over saturation, more subtle and usually better on skin tones. Prioritize natural skin over “cool cinematic” vibes.

Avoid orange faces : too warm and red faces, that’s too much saturation. Keep whites of eyes natural: no blueish whitening.

Selective Desaturation





Car Show, Redmond WA. "Ferrari Day" - In the above example, almost everything around the car has been cropped away and turned black and white. The red hues on the car have been boosted.

A truly 'special' effect to use wisely…

Sharpening

Always sharpen your photos at the very end of the editing process.

Zoom deep into the image to at least 200% or more to evaluate and judge sharpening: This step can be detrimental to the quality of the image, always increasing digital noise. While just a bit of noise is usually fine, excessive sharpening is not. There should be no color dots regularly spaced in the dark areas of the image.

And yes, sometimes there is no need for sharpening.

Special Filters

Photo Rebel allows you mix black and white or sepia images into your original. Other special effects are available, such as Polaroid, vignette and a few more.

Another interesting filter is the Hue Rotation effect as shown below:





The Ridge Motorsports Park - Shelton WA. "Bikers Day" - In the above example, Photo Rebel has rotated all colors quite a lot! Possibly too much.

However, rotating colors by one or two degrees on the color wheel can provide interesting and surprising effects on the image.

Editing - Step Four - Review and Export

Nobody watching you, you will be your very own judge: Compare side by side your editing final result and your original.
There MUST be improvements, it MUST be better.

Export the raw image to the desired format and rate again the image.

Photo Rebel allows to add watermarks, signatures and frames during the Export process.
Like all serious photo editing software, Photo Rebel had saved all your editing steps and has left the original absolutely unchanged.





Crater Lake National Park, Oregon - Cropped for the rule of thirds and to get closer to the island, white balance using the foreground snow as the reference point, just a bit vibrance on the red channel, and a little touch of sharpening to reveal footprints in the snow.

Editing - Step Five - Post-Mortem

Why Do My Edited Photos Look Bad? Or Not so Good?

If your edits look “off” even though you’re trying all the sliders, you’re not alone.

Most edited photos look bad for a few predictable reasons: too much contrast, weird color, crunchy sharpness,
or edits that fight the original light.

This section breaks down the most common mistakes so your photos look clean, natural, and intentionally edited without the over processed vibe.

The Edit Is Too Strong: The Number ONE Problem

When an edit looks bad, it's usually not the idea; it's the intensity.
Phones and social apps make it easy to push sliders too far.

Try to reduce your adjustments by 30–50% and compare.
Toggle "before/after." If the edit shocks you, it's too much.

Composition

Common mistakes for composition, rotation and cropping usually mitigate or even resolve most of them.

- Placing the subject dead-centre every time.

- Cropping someone at the wrist, ankle, or knee looks awkward and unintentional.

- Horizons are always horizontal. Period.

- No subject, no foreground. Crop to zoom in, if needed.

- No leading lines: Roads, fences, rivers, staircases, etc.

- Declutter: Bring empty space, remove distracting elements.

- Simplify: One thing to say, stronger.

This is where you should spend most of the time you want to dedicate to editing.

Highlights Are Blown Out - Or Shadows Are Crushed

Bright skies, windows, and white clothing get ruined fast.

On the other side, deep shadows can turn into muddy black patches with no detail.

Keep detail in the brightest and darkest areas when possible.

Do not try to illuminate entirely the image: you should not light a scene so perfectly that every single detail is visible. When a scene is completely and evenly lit, it will look flat, two-dimensional, and artificial. Total illumination feels sterile, like a hospital room or a supermarket. Allowing shadows into the image creates contrast, which instantly introduces mood, mystery, romance, or tension.

Everything Looks "Weird".

Most likely the White Balance is the problem: Bad color is the fastest way to make an edit look amateur.
If skin looks orange, shadows look green, or the photo feels cold and lifeless, then white balance is the culprit.

Adjust temperature until whites look neutral, white or gray - not yellow or blue. Use color grading later to eventually correct green/magenta casts.
Don't "guess." Zoom in on something that should be neutral, such as a white wall, a gray shirt, a piece of paper, and use it as the reference point for the 'White Patch' algorithm.

Too Much Sharpening

Sharpening can make landscapes and buildings pop, but they can wreck portraits and make everything look harsh, gritty, and over-sharpened.

Portrait rule: Skin MUST look natural. If pores, wrinkles, or noise suddenly dominate the photo, you went too far.

Phone images are already sharpened by default. Adding more sharpness often creates halos around edges and makes noise look worse. Reduce sharpening, then try to start with a bit of noise reduction.

'Cartoonification'

Heavy saturation makes blues neon, skin orange, and greens radioactive. It also destroys subtle tones and looks fake fast. Prefer vibrance over saturation for a more natural boost.

For portraits, if your model's skin looks sunburnt or reddish, saturation is almost always the reason.

Your Edits are Fighting against each other

Many people apply a filter, then also crank another one (exposure, contrast or saturation) on top.
That stacking is a common reason edits look muddy or unnatural.

You're Editing a 'Bad' Photo

Editing can enhance a good photo, but it cannot fully rescue harsh overhead sun, mixed indoor lighting, or super dark blurry shots. If the light is fighting you, your edit will look worse the harder you push it.